# The Words You'll Hear at the Hospital: Levels of Care on One Page

Seventeen terms in one plain line each, and what to write down when you hear them.

Skilled care, custodial care, assisted living, memory care. The staff use these words all day, and nobody stops to explain them. These are the ones you're most likely to hear around a discharge, each described from a public source, with what to write down when it comes up.

The descriptions are for following the conversation. They aren't for working out what Mom needs or what she qualifies for. That belongs to the people who assess her and to professionals who know her state.

## Care needs

### Long-term care

A range of services and supports a person may need to meet personal care needs. Most of it is not medical care, but help with the basic personal tasks of everyday life. [1]

**WRITE DOWN** The everyday tasks someone helps Mom with now.

### Activities of daily living (ADLs)

The basic personal tasks: bathing, dressing, using the toilet, moving to or from a bed or chair, caring for incontinence, and eating. [1]

**WRITE DOWN** Which ones you've seen her do on her own, and which with help.

### Instrumental activities of daily living (IADLs)

Everyday tasks such as housework, managing money, taking medication, preparing meals, shopping and using the telephone. [1]

**WRITE DOWN** Who did each of these before the hospital.

### Skilled care

Nursing and therapy care that can only be safely and effectively performed by, or under the supervision of, professionals or technical personnel. [2]

**WRITE DOWN** Which skilled services the staff say she is getting now.

### Custodial care

Another name for long-term care: help with activities of daily living, like bathing, dressing or eating. [3]

**WRITE DOWN** Who used the word about Mom, and what help they meant.

## Where care is given

### Care at home

Most long-term care is provided at home, by family members and friends, or by a nurse, a home health or home care aide, or a therapist who comes to the home. [4]

**WRITE DOWN** Who could help at home, with what, and on which days.

### Assisted living

Housing and services for people who need some help with daily care but do not need the medical care that a nursing home provides. [5]

**WRITE DOWN** Any place that was mentioned, and who mentioned it.

### Memory care

The public sources we checked don't define this one. MedlinePlus notes that assisted living residents are usually older adults, including people with Alzheimer's or other types of dementia. [5]

**WRITE DOWN** What each place says its memory care includes, in their words.

### Nursing home

A facility for people who usually need 24-hour care. Nursing homes provide the most comprehensive range of services, including nursing care and 24-hour supervision. [3] [4]

**WRITE DOWN** Whether one has been suggested, and the reason given.

### Skilled nursing facility (SNF)

Nursing homes can give short-term care to people who need rehabilitation after surgery or skilled nursing to recover from an illness. In a skilled nursing facility, a team from different medical fields plans the care. [3] [6]

**WRITE DOWN** Whether Mom's stay is being described as short-term, and by whom.

## People and plans

### Discharge planning

The process that determines the kind of care a patient needs after leaving the hospital. [7]

**WRITE DOWN** Where it stands today, and when you'll talk next.

### Discharge planner

Your point person for the discharge. Some hospitals have a dedicated one; it could also be a social worker, a nurse or another member of staff. [7]

**WRITE DOWN** Their name and direct phone number.

### Care plan

In a skilled nursing facility, the plan the staff prepare or update after each assessment of a person's condition. The family can help plan the care. [6]

**WRITE DOWN** Whether you've seen it, and who to tell that you want to be involved.

## Paying for care

### Medicare and long-term care

Medicare.gov's general statement is that Medicare generally doesn't cover long-term care in a nursing home. What it covers for Mom is a question for the facility, her plan or Medicare. [8]

**WRITE DOWN** Which kind of Medicare coverage Mom has, and the phone number on her card.

### Medicaid

A joint federal and state government program that helps some people pay their health care bills. Its eligibility rules and covered services vary from state to state, so what it means for Mom is a question for a professional who knows her state. [9]

**WRITE DOWN** Your questions about it, for your Medicaid planner.

### Private pay (out-of-pocket)

Paying for care yourselves. Most people who enter nursing homes start by paying for their care out-of-pocket. [8]

**WRITE DOWN** What you pay now, to whom, and what it includes.

### Long-term care insurance

Insurance that can help pay for many types of long-term care, including both skilled and non-skilled care. Policies vary widely. [8]

**WRITE DOWN** Whether Mom has a policy, and where it is kept.

**What this sheet doesn't do**

It describes words. It doesn't tell you which of them apply to Mom, what level of care she needs, or what Medicare or Medicaid will cover for her. Those answers come from the people who assess her and from professionals who know her state. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

## Ready for the next step?

You can follow the words now, and you've noted what was said about Mom. The care interview covers the same ground in plain language: it walks you through her situation one area at a time and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

**Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›**

### WHERE THIS COMES FROM


1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), What is Long-Term Care?
2. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), SNF Care Coverage
3. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Nursing Home Coverage
4. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Where Can You Receive Care?
5. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Assisted Living: MedlinePlus
6. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Assessments & care plans in Skilled Nursing Facilities
7. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
8. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), How can I pay for nursing home care?
9. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Medicaid